Autocracy of the Tsar Nicholas II



Tsar Nicholas II

Tsar Nicholas II of the Romanov dynasty had little experience of government. His wife Alexandra was a dominant personality and Nicholas was under her strong influence. Determined that Russia should not be left out in the scramble for colonial possessions, Nicholas encouraged Russian expansion in Manchuria, provoking a war with Japan in 1904. The resulting Russian defeat led to strikes and riots. Opposition to the Tsar grew.

On 23 January 1905 Father Gapon, organised a march of men, women and children. The processions were peaceful and unarmed, with demands for a representative national assembly, and agrarian and industrial reforms. But police and soldiers fired on the procession. Hundreds were killed and many thousands wounded. The events of this day (known as Bloody Sunday) led to riots, strikes and violence in which the governor-general of Moscow, was killed by a bomb.

Nicholas was forced to grant a constitution and establish a parliament, the Duma. This was no longer satisfactory to the left-wing parties that formed a soviet (council) of workers' delegates in St Petersburg. Similar soviets were set up in other cities. The Duma gave the middle classes, a voice in government. So the moderates were supportive of the government's policy, while the left wing continued their opposition. But whenever the Duma opposed any initiative of the Tsar, it was dissolved and fresh elections were held. Without change of government policy, the fourth Duma ended with the revolution of 1917.

Opposition to the Tsar and Dissolution of Duma

The outbreak of the First World War had temporarily strengthened the monarchy, as Russia was allied to France and Britain. As there was a rumour of a palace revolution, Nicholas made himself the Commander-in-Chief of his army and was making a mess of everything. Towards the end of 1916, Rasputin, a domineering influence over the Tsar and the Tsarina, was murdered creating a crisis in the palace. Members of the St. Petersburg Soviet were arrested.

Popular Uprisings

As late as on 23 February 1917, when the socialists celebrated International Working Women's Day, the Tsar seemed unchallengeable. But he had to abdicate on the morning of 2 March. Though none called for strikes, the bread shortages among women textile workers, with their husbands in the army, forced them to go on strike anyway and march through the factory areas of Petrograd. Masses of women workers in a militant frame of mind demanding "Bread for workers" waved their arms towards factory workers and shouted "Come out!" "Stop work!" The city's 400,000 workers joined the movement the next day (24 February).

Abdication of Tsar

The government used the military to break the strike. But on the fourth day of strikes and demonstrations mutinies broke out even in the barracks. The Tsar declared martial law. But his order was not broadcast in the city, as there was no one to do this job. The Tsar then tried to return to Petrograd. The railway workers stopped his train on the way. Frightened by these developments, the generals at the front and some leaders in Petrograd, pleaded with the Tsar to abdicate. On 15 March, a week after the popular uprisings, Nicholas II abdicated.

Provisional Government

There were two parallel bodies to take on government functions. One consisted of bourgeois politicians of the old state Duma, representing the propertied classes. On the other were the workers' delegates drawn together in a workers' council, or Soviet. The soviets were influenced by the underground left-wingers. Those in the Duma were able to form a provincial government with the consent

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